

Benefits and Purpose of Astanga Yoga

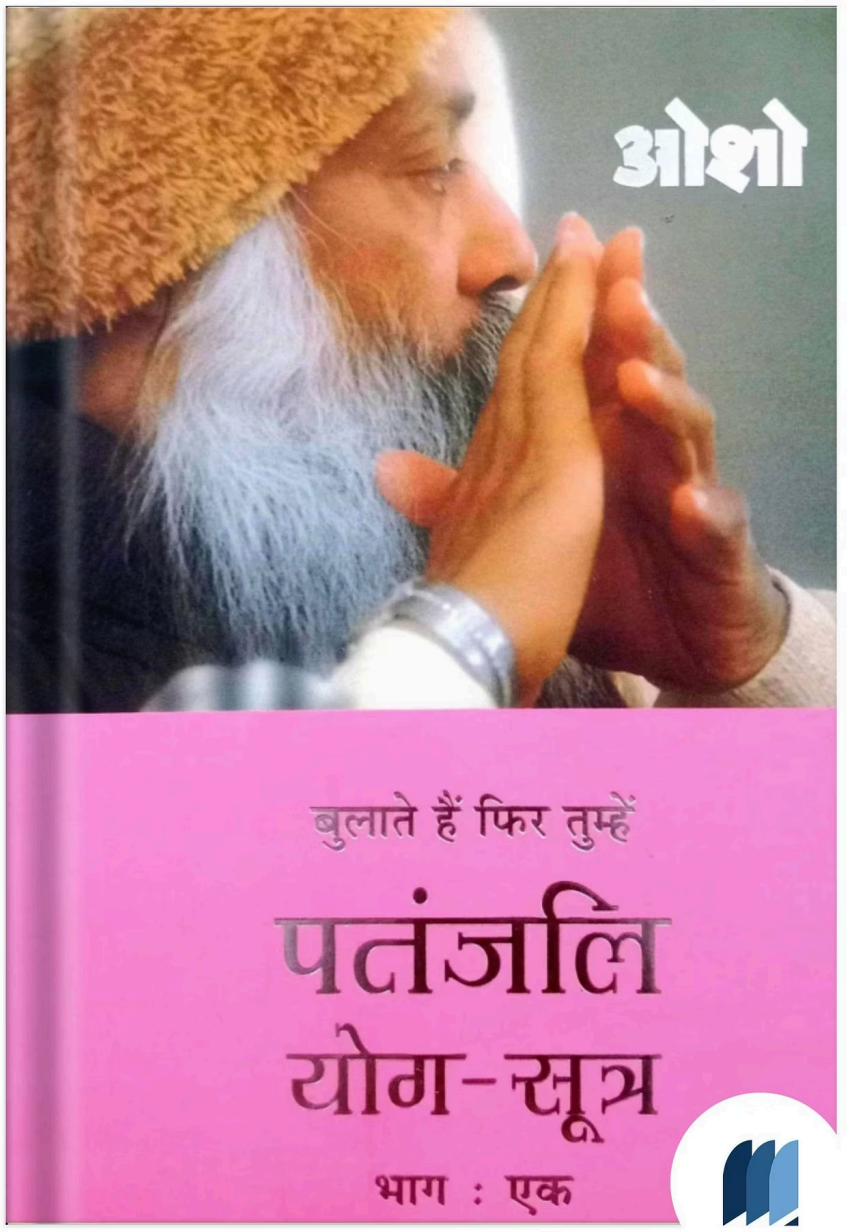
The Path to Holistic Union

Presented by **Badal** · Lucknow University

Made with GAMMA

FOUNDATIONS

What Is Astanga Yoga?



The word **Astanga** derives from Sanskrit: *ashta* (eight) + *anga* (limbs). It refers to the eightfold path of yoga systematically outlined by **Sage Patanjali** in the *Yoga Sutras* (~400 BCE).

Patanjali's Yoga Sutras is considered the foundational text of classical yoga philosophy, offering a practical guide to stilling the mind and realizing one's true nature.

Made with GAMMA

CORE PURPOSE

Chitta Vritti Nirodhah

"Yoga is the cessation of the fluctuations of the mind."

— Patanjali, Yoga Sutras 1.2

The ultimate aim of Astanga Yoga is not merely physical fitness — it is **self-realization**. By quieting the restless patterns of thought, the practitioner moves inward, from the outer world of action toward the still center of pure awareness.



Made with GAMMA

LIMBS 1 & 2

The Ethical Foundations: Yama & Niyama

Yama — Social Restraints

Ahimsa

Non-violence toward all beings

Satya

Truthfulness in thought and speech

Asteya

Non-stealing; contentment with what is

Niyama — Personal Observances

Saucha

Purity of body and mind

Santosha

Contentment in all circumstances

Tapas

Disciplined effort and inner fire

Made with GAMMA

LIMBS 3 & 4

Physical Mastery: Asana & Pranayama



Asana — The Steady Seat

Postures cultivate strength, flexibility, and stillness — preparing the body to sit comfortably in meditation. A stable body supports a stable mind.

Pranayama — Breath as Life Force

Controlled breathing regulates *prana* (vital energy), calms the nervous system, and increases lung capacity. It is the bridge between body and mind.

Made with GAMMA

LIMB 5

Pratyahara: The Withdrawal of the Senses

The Turning Inward

Pratyahara is the fifth limb — the quiet pivot from external engagement to internal awareness. The senses are not suppressed; they are gently **disengaged from outward objects** and drawn toward the inner self.

This limb marks the transition from the *bahiranga* (external) practices to the *antaranga* (internal) practices of the mind.



Like a tortoise withdrawing its limbs, the practitioner retracts the senses from the world.

Made with GAMMA

LIMBS 6 & 7

Dharana & Dhyana: Concentration and Meditation

Dharana — Focused Concentration

The mind is fixed upon a single point — the breath, a mantra, or an image. Distractions are gently acknowledged and released. This is the *training* of attention.

Dhyana — Flowing Meditation

When concentration becomes effortless and continuous, it deepens into Dhyana — an unbroken stream of awareness. The observer and the observed begin to merge.



Made with GAMMA



LIMB 8 · THE ULTIMATE GOAL

Samadhi: Union with the Divine

Samadhi is the eighth and final limb — a state of **pure consciousness** where the sense of a separate self dissolves. The practitioner experiences complete equanimity, oneness with existence, and liberation from suffering.

Savikalpa Samadhi

Union with form; awareness of duality remains

Nirvikalpa Samadhi

Formless union; complete transcendence of self

Made with GAMMA

KEY BENEFITS

What Astanga Yoga Offers the Practitioner

Physical Prowess

Improves flexibility, builds core strength, and corrects posture through disciplined asana practice.

Mental Resilience

Reduces cortisol levels, sharpens focus, and cultivates emotional steadiness under pressure.

Respiratory Efficiency

Pranayama increases lung capacity and oxygenates the blood, energizing the entire system.

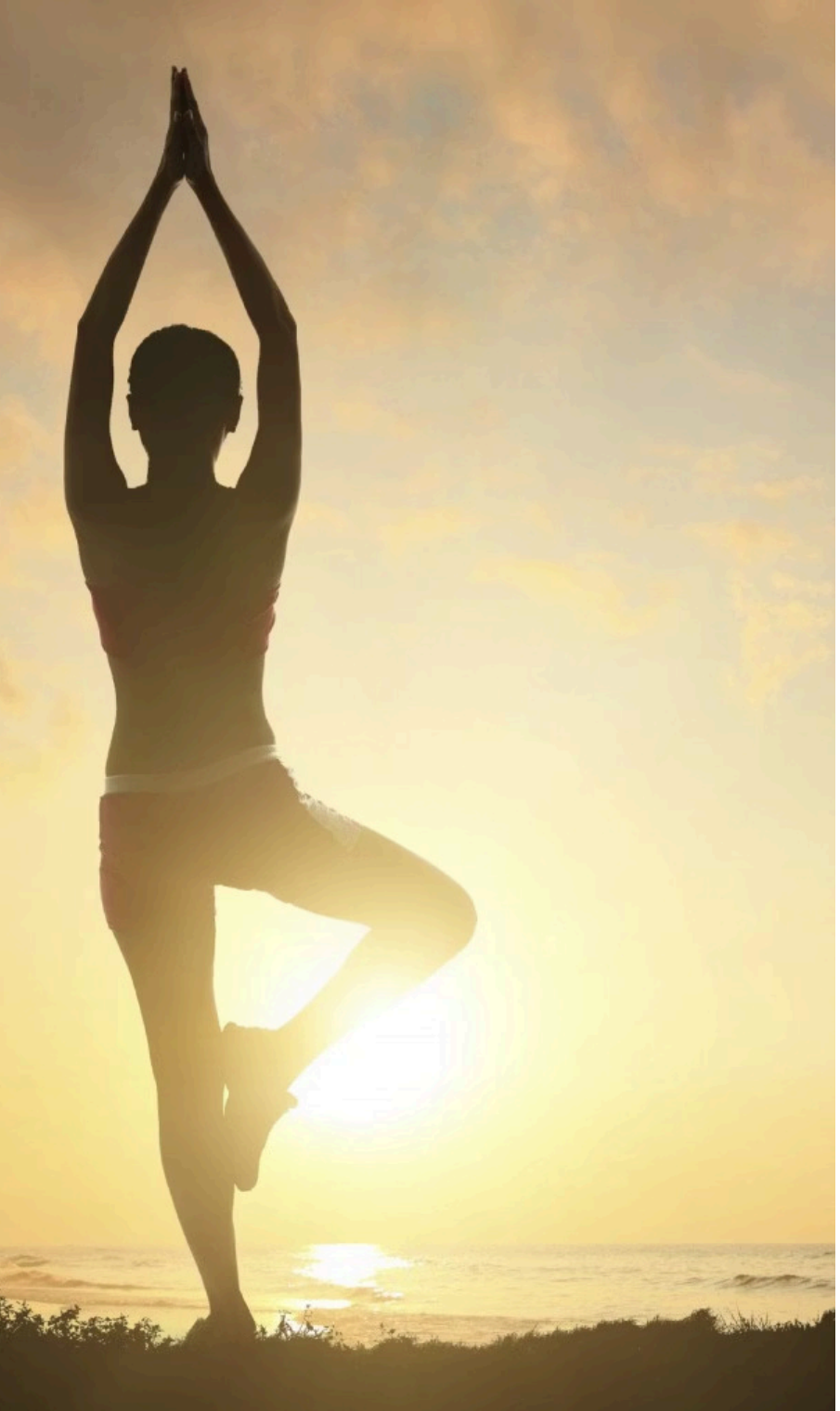
Nervous System Regulation

Balances the sympathetic and parasympathetic nervous systems, promoting calm and recovery.

Ethical Living

Ahimsa and Satya improve relationships and foster a compassionate, truthful way of life.

Made with GAMMA



CONCLUSION

Ancient Wisdom for Modern Student Life

The eight limbs of Astanga Yoga are not relics of the past — they are a **living framework** for navigating the pressures of academic life, relationships, and personal growth at Lucknow University and beyond.

Begin with ethics

Practice Ahimsa and Satya in daily interactions.

Train the body and breath

Even 15 minutes of asana and pranayama transforms your day.

Cultivate inner stillness

Meditation is not escape — it is clarity for engaged living.

Questions & Reflections Welcome

Made with GAMMA